Vayishlach 5784

פרשת וישלח. The מלאכים that יעקב sent to find out what עשו was up to returned to יעקב with the famous פסוק (32:7): בָּאנוּ אֶל אָחִיךָ אֶל עֵשָׂו וְגַם הֹלֵךְ לִקְרָאתְךָ וְאַרְבַּע מֵאוֹת אִישׁ עִמּוֹ. This was a frightening report: עשו is coming with a force of men, and his apparent intention is to do harm.

In response, יעקב adopted three strategies to prepare for this encounter (רש"י ל"ב:ט'):

1. דורון – sending gifts to עשו as a bribe.
2. תפילה – davening to הקדוש ברוך הוא for protection.
3. מלחמה – preparing for battle in case it became necessary.

יעקב was a highly capable warrior, but עשו was equally formidable. The מפרשים explain that יעקב feared not only the possibility of עשו killing him and his family, but also the prospect of killing עשו himself. He wanted to avoid war if possible.

When they finally met, an extraordinary thing occurred: יעקב bowed down to עשו, and עשו responded by giving him a kiss. Surprisingly, כמעט all the מפרשים comment that עשו meant the kiss genuinely. This raises the question: how was such a transformation possible?

The answer lies in the power of תפילה, which can accomplish anything.

Many examples brought down in storybooks, or in מעשה ביכלעך as they say, illustrate this interesting concept. There are numerous stories about great personalities from the old ישוב in ארץ ישראל - giants of spirituality and character about whom we know very little. I had the זכות to meet the אלמנה of רב נחום דוד הרמן, the son of the famous "All for the Boss" יעקב יוסף הרמן. I told her I had named one of my children after her late husband נחום דוד. She graciously showed me his library and allowed me to take any ספר I wanted. Of course, I was a young man. I didn't really fully grasp what opportunities were there. So I chapped a few ספרים and one of them turned out to be a book called הַפּוֹתֵחַ שער by אליהו כי טוב, a fascinating book about the old ישוב of ירושלים.

A story in the ספר tells of רב נחום Shadeker. There's even a street in ירושלים named after him. The story involves a מוֹסֵר - a black belt troublemaker - named Grunchi Getches. He was notorious, stealing from peddlers and bullying people. Today we would call him a mafioso, really not a good guy. Once, he went so far as to slap רב נחום.

Grunchi eventually disappeared for a while, but later, as רב נחום was traveling out of town for a שמחה with one of his תלמידים, they spotted Grunchi approaching with a group of men. The תלמיד warned, "That's Grunchi Getches, and he's out to get you." Remarkably, רב נחום remained calm, closed his eyes, and appeared deeply focused. When Grunchi reached רב נחום, he bowed down, apologized for his actions, and asked for forgiveness. It was an incredible נס.

When they returned home, the תלמידים asked רב נחום how he had managed this. He replied that he had followed the example of יעקב אבינו, citing the פסוק from משלי (27:19): כַּמַּיִם הַפָּנִים לַפָּנִים כֵּן לֵב הָאָדָם לָאָדָם - Just as water reflects a person's face, so too does one person's heart reflect another's. רב נחום explained that he did exactly the same thing that יעקב אבינו did. יעקב forgave עשו with all of his heart, for all of the things that he did to him. And the trick is, he meant it. He didn't just say it, he meant it. רב נחום said, "I did the same thing. I worked on myself to forgive Grunchi completely, with a full heart, believing that Grunchi's actions stemmed from difficult life circumstances. By truly forgiving him, I removed the שִׂנְאָה from my heart, which reflexively softened Grunchi's heart."

This teaches us the profound power of being דן לכף זכות and finding the good in others. It's a vital tool in combating שנאת חינם and other מידות רעות.

https://youtu.be/tZb91kNFXtk

It's a very good thing to adopt the following מנהג which I saw, that every morning before starting davening, I ask Hashem to grant עליית נשמה to all the members of my family. Through the זכות of my davening, I ask that all of those נשמות in the עולם האמת should have נחת, including my dear parents, my dear brother, my dear in-laws, my dear uncle whom I never met but am named after, יְהוֹנָתָן בִּנְיָמִין, and all of my grandparents.

After that, I say: הֲרֵינִי מְקַבֵּל עַל עַצְמִי מִצְוַת עֲשֵׂה שֶׁל וְאָהַבְתָּ לְרֵעֲךָ כָּמוֹךָ. This is from the אריז"ל, I heard it from Rabbi Oelbaum, and since I mentioned it in his name, משיח should come any moment now. I'll say it again, and I can even make you a copy if you want: הֲרֵינִי מְקַבֵּל עַל עַצְמִי מִצְוַת עֲשֵׂה שֶׁל וְאָהַבְתָּ לְרֵעֲךָ כָּמוֹךָ.

This is a fantastic thing to do before davening. It's included in some of the very big chassidish סידורים. I made copies of it - I keep one in the car, another in my סידור. But it's not just about saying it; it's about doing it. If we truly work on this, we can see things go our way - not because we want things to go our way, but because we want things to go the right way, לשם שמים.

May our עבודה be מקובל, and in that זכות, may we see ישועות and נחמות, im yirtzeh Hashem, for all כלל ישראל.

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